Shenzhen Kstar Science & Tech (002518.SZ): First Take: 3Q26 sales miss but resilient margins; data center order outlook intact; Buy

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On Oct 26, 2026, Kstar announced 3Q26 results that missed GSe with sluggish renewable products sales (-8% yoy per GSe) and FX losses of Rmb-13mn, while data center products sales growth (+21% yoy per GSe) remained solid. 3Q26 sales/GP/OP/NP were Rmb1,578mn/467mn/233mn/211mn (+9%/+16%/+12%/+11% yoy, +17%/+19%/+33%/+40% qoq), -6%/-8%/-11%/-11% vs. GSe. 3Q26 GPM/OPM/NPM were 30%/15%/13% (+2pp/0pp/0pp yoy, 0pp/+2pp/+2pp), -1pp/-1pp/-1pp vs. GSe, supported by favorable product mix (high portion of high-power UPS and C&I ESS) and regional mix (with higher overseas contribution). The company expects **data center products sales to achieve both yoy and qoq growth in 4Q26, driven by accelerating new orders momentum that began around May 2026 and further strengthened recently in Sep-Oct.** Additionally, the company expects **multiple new volume orders from global electricals customers will arrive around 1Q27**. Regarding Chinese customers, Kstar has observed **improving data center construction activities from domestic hyperscalers in both China and Southeast Asia since mid-2026 and is positive on their demand growth in 2027-28**, following easing AI chip supply constraints. Meanwhile, Kstar plans to commence 800 VDC onsite testing in Nov 2026 and targets SST prototype launches in 1H27 as it aligns development timelines with evolving industry readiness, noting no clear signs of imminent industry-wide mass adoption for either technology. Management reiterated 2026 ESS sales guidance of Rmb1.5bn (~+50% yoy), with improving GPM driven by a higher C&I mix. Solar inverter and EV charging sales remained subdued, but the impact on firmwide net profit has been relatively limited given the lower GPM of these segments. Maintain Buy.

Key takeaways from the earnings call on Oct 27:

Data center product sales were +21% in 3Q26 at Rmb1,070mn (GSe, accounting for 67% of total sales), contributing to >80% of firmwide net profits. By region, overseas sales (>+20% yoy) were slightly higher than domestic sales (+10%~20% yoy). The company expects segment sales to see yoy and qoq growth in 4Q26, driven by **accelerating new orders momentum that began around May 2026 and further strengthened recently in Sep-Oct.**

- In the overseas markets, mid/high-power products now account for c.50% of overseas data center product sales, driven by the AIDC buildout demand across Europe, US, and SEA. Revenue contribution from colocation (colo) customers has

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increased meaningfully in 2026. Additionally, the company expects **multiple new volume orders from global electricals customers will arrive around 1Q27** after meeting their testing requirements. Kstar will ramp up its direct shipment to the North American market in 2027 utilizing its manufacturing capacity in Vietnam. This is backed by a recently secured US$60mn order from an existing European customer and demand from colo customers.

- With Chinese customers, Kstar has observed **improving data center construction activities from Chinese hyperscalers (e.g. Alibaba and ByteDance) in both China and Southeast Asia since mid-2026**, following easing AI chip supply constraints. The company remains positive on data center buildout demand from domestic hyperscalers in 2027-28.
- Segment GPM remained resilient at c.35% as the headwinds from FX and higher raw material costs were offset by a favorable product mix (high portion of high-power UPS) and regional mix (with higher overseas contribution).

800 VDC product development ongoing without clear signs of industry-wide mass adoption so far: Following design changes and internal testing, Kstar plans to commence onsite testing in Europe and Southeast Asia in November 2026 (vs. targeting October previously). While the company believes it is aligned with industry development, it does not expect imminent global mass adoption. For solid state transformers (SSTs), the launch of SST prototypes is now planned for 1H27 (previously targeting module launch by end-2026 and systems in 2027). Management cited industry-wide challenges regarding raw materials and supply chain readiness for large-scale SST deployment.

Renewables segment sales declined -8% to Rmb513mn (GSe, accounting for 33% of total sales).

- ESS sales reached Rmb341mn (GSe) in 3Q26, moderating to +3% yoy growth, likely due to slower residential ESS demand as key ODM customer SolarEdge faces intense competition in Europe. Conversely, the Commercial & Industrial (C&I) ESS business maintained strong growth in Europe, Australia, and South America during the quarter and is expected to surpass the residential segment for full-year 2026, per the company. Management reiterated FY2026 ESS sales guidance of Rmb1.5bn (~+50% YoY), with improving GPM driven by a higher C&I mix.
- Solar inverter sales were subdued at Rmb153mn in 3Q26 (-15% yoy), impacted by the domestic new solar installation weakness. EV charging sales were <Rmb100mn in 1-3Q26 also declining yoy. However, the impact on firmwide net profit has been relatively limited given the lower GPM of these segments.

Operating cash flow turned negative to -Rmb38mn in 3Q26 (vs. +Rmb357mn in 3Q25 / +Rmb64mn in 2Q26) as the company ramped up inventory, particularly for semiconductor components such as SiC and high-power IGBT modules. Capex totaled Rmb74mn (+22% yoy / +27% qoq), reflecting investments in new facilities in Shenzhen and Huizhou for AIDC power products, as well as preparations for direct North American order production at the Vietnam factory.

Exhibit 1: Kstar 3Q26 financial summary

Kstar (002518.SZ)	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26	yoy %	qoq %	Prior 3Q26 Gse	Diff
Revenue (Rmb mn)	**943**	**1,219**	**1,446**	**1,662**	**1,240**	**1,351**	**1,578**	**9%**	**17%**	**1,680**	**-6%**
Gross profit (Rmb mn)	277	350	404	497	369	394	467	16%	19%	507	-8%
EBIT (Rmb mn)	103	140	208	172	163	174	233	12%	33%	262	-11%
Net profit (Rmb mn)	**111**	**144**	**190**	**165**	**139**	**151**	**211**	**11%**	**40%**	**238**	**-11%**
EPS (Rmb)	**0.19**	**0.25**	**0.33**	**0.28**	**0.24**	**0.26**	**0.36**	**11%**	**40%**	**0.41**	**-11%**
Gross margin (Rmb mn)	**29%**	**29%**	**28%**	**30%**	**30%**	**29%**	**30%**	**2pp**	**0pp**	**30%**	**-1qq**
EBIT margin (Rmb mn)	**11%**	**11%**	**14%**	**10%**	**13%**	**13%**	**15%**	**0pp**	**2pp**	**16%**	**-1qq**
Net margin (Rmb mn)	**12%**	**12%**	**13%**	**10%**	**11%**	**11%**	**13%**	**0pp**	**2pp**	**14%**	**-1qq**

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

002518.SZ	12m Price Target: Rmb60	Price: Rmb27.11	Upside: 121.3%

Buy

Market cap: Rmb15.8bn / $2.4bn
Enterprise value: Rmb15.2bn / $2.3bn
3m ADTV :Rmb512.1mn/ $76.3mn
China
China Industrial Tech & Machinery
M&A Rank: 3
Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: No

GS Forecast

	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
Revenue (Rmb mn)	5,270.3	6,213.6	7,946.2	9,787.6
EBITDA (Rmb mn)	731.2	988.4	1,374.8	1,788.3
EPS (Rmb)	1.05	1.33	1.95	2.56
P/E (X)	29.5	20.4	13.9	10.6
P/B (X)	3.7	3.0	2.6	2.2
Dividend yield (%)	1.5	2.2	3.6	4.7
N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	(0.4)	(0.6)	(0.7)	(0.7)
CROCI (%)	18.2	21.1	23.3	27.1
FCF yield (%)	4.0	4.0	4.2	6.2

	3/26	6/26	9/26E	12/26E
EPS (Rmb)	0.24	0.26	0.41	0.42

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 27 Oct 2026 close.

Investment thesis, valuation methodology, and risks

Investment thesis: Kstar specializes in electric power conversion technology, providing data centers and energy storage systems (ESS) with a constant and stable power supply. It has achieved the largest UPS (uninterruptible power supply) shipments in China for more than 20 years (per CCID). For Kstar, we expect the company to deliver solid revenue/net income growth, mainly driven by: (1) overseas AIDC customer expansion and product innovation (including high-power UPS, 800 VDC, SST etc.) serving a broader regions including the North American market; (2) domestic data center revenue growth pick-up, riding on increased capex from both SOE and POE hyperscalers and expanding customer base in the domestic data center market, and (3) overseas ESS business recovery benefiting from channel inventories normalization and C&I ESS demand. We are Buy rated on the stock considering the attractive P/E valuation on its long-term growth profile and better margin and returns vs. peers.

Price target risks & methodology: Our 12m target price of Rmb60.0 is based on 2028E P/E of 26x discounted back to 2027E at 11% CoE. Key downside risks: (1) Lower-than-expected US ODM order growth; (2) Slower new product launches especially 800V DC products; (3) Lower-than-expected overseas ESS growth and margin.

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Reg AC

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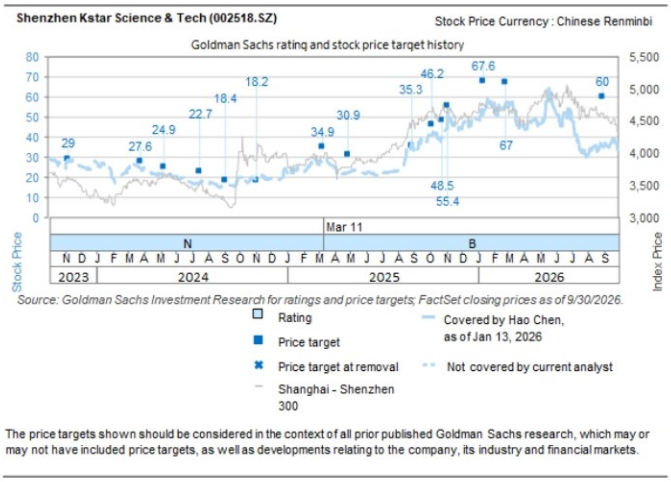
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Target price history table(s)

Shenzhen Kstar Science & Tech (002518.SZ)

Date of report	Target price (Rmb)	Closing price (Rmb)
30-Aug-26	60.00	35.47
25-Feb-26	67.00	54.61
13-Jan-26	67.60	51.09
06-Nov-25	55.40	48.73
26-Oct-25	48.50	39.10
07-Oct-25	46.20	41.29
28-Aug-25	35.30	37.90
28-Apr-25	30.90	21.98
11-Mar-25	34.90	28.38
04-Nov-24	18.20	19.39
05-Sep-24	18.40	16.45
18-Jul-24	22.70	17.30
09-May-24	24.90	22.46
27-Mar-24	27.60	23.24
07-Nov-23	29.00	28.56

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